

Richard van Zyl

Solutions Architect / Technical Lead — Backend & Data-Intensive Systems

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Professional Summary

Solutions Architect and Technical Lead with **nine years** across C#/.NET and SQL Server — ~5 of them leading teams and ~3.5 as Solutions Architect — building high-throughput, multi-tenant financial systems where data integrity is non-negotiable. Deep specialist in backend engineering and relational data: execution-plan tuning, concurrency control, partitioning, and idempotent transaction design for ledgers operating across African markets. Requirements and solution design have run through the whole of that — specifying and modelling systems as a business analyst since 2017, pitched to whichever audience had to sign them off.

I own delivery end-to-end — from eliciting the requirement and modelling the solution, through concurrency and multi-tenancy strategy, to CI/CD and production telemetry — while leading teams and acting as the translation layer between engineering and the business. A problem solver at heart; languages and frameworks are simply tools. Regularly handed the challenges others could not solve, from turning around failed legacy migrations to designing the financial engine that replaced a legacy banking platform.

Core Competencies

Requirements & Solution Design — Business (BRS), user (URS), functional (FRS) and technical (TRS) requirements specification; business- and problem-domain analysis; solution design and solution architecture; process and system modelling (UML / Enterprise Architect); stakeholder engagement and translation between business and engineering; audience-tailored technical writing.

Architecture & Design — Domain-Driven Design (DDD), CQRS, Event-Driven Architecture, Microservices, Multi-tenancy & Tenant Isolation, Idempotency / Exactly-Once Processing, RESTful API design, Clean Architecture.

Databases & Data — Microsoft SQL Server, Azure SQL, T-SQL, SQL Performance Tuning (execution plans, indexing, locking & isolation levels, deadlock resolution), Table Partitioning & Archiving, In-Memory OLTP, PostgreSQL, MySQL, Redis (distributed caching), MongoDB, Entity Framework.

Backend & Languages — C# (.NET Core, .NET 6+, ASP.NET Core, ASP.NET Web API), MediatR, FluentValidation, AutoMapper, Polly; SQL / T-SQL; TypeScript, JavaScript, Node.js.

Messaging & Integration — Azure Service Bus, RabbitMQ, API Gateway (Azure API Management), SignalR / WebSockets.

Cloud, DevOps & Observability — Microsoft Azure, Azure DevOps, **Azure DevOps YAML pipelines (pipeline-as-code)**, Docker on Azure hosts, AKS / Kubernetes, Azure CI/CD, GitHub, Trunk-based & GitFlow branching, Feature Flags. Observability: **New Relic** (release tracking wired through the DevOps pipeline, key-transaction instrumentation, alerting into MS Teams), OpenTelemetry, Grafana, Graylog over UDP, ActiveXperts, Azure Monitor / Application Insights / Log Analytics, Elastic Stack (ELK) / Serilog.

Security & Compliance — OAuth2 / OpenID Connect / JWT, Role-Based Access Control (RBAC), KYC / AML domains, SOX-aligned data segregation, data-protection-aware design (POPIA / GDPR).

AI & Agentic Engineering — Multi-model routing and evaluation (Claude, GitHub Copilot, Cursor, OpenAI Codex, Grok); agent orchestration with dependency-aware planning and budget governance; MCP server integration; automated standards review and analyzer-enforced quality gates; ADR-driven decision capture.

Testing & Tooling — xUnit, NUnit, Moq, Integration Testing (TestContainers); Enterprise Architect (UML), Swagger, Postman, SSRS; Angular, Angular Material; Agile, Scrum.

Selected Achievements

- **Architected a multi-tenant, white-label financial engine** serving two operators (Betway and Jackpot City) from one configuration-driven codebase — 2 tenants, 25 brands, 150+ payment methods. Target isolation was database-per-brand; production constraint was one SQL Server with schema-per-brand and request-scoped contexts, because separate databases were priced out.
 - **Sustained deposit volumes in excess of €10M on peak trading days**, absorbing both steady casino throughput and large spikes during live sporting events.
 - **Eliminated double-spend race conditions** under heavy contention by designing idempotent attempt records keyed to a unique identifier, with rowversion-based optimistic concurrency on the ledger — exactly-once withdrawal processing under contention.
 - **Solved problems others had abandoned:** completed a .NET 6 migration that had been attempted and rolled back by previous developers, and resolved a 2-year Angular Universal SEO blocker in one week.
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Professional Experience

Co-owner / Solutions Architect

Yuno Technologies · Digital consultancy · Apr 2026 – present

Half-owner of a South African digital consultancy, leading technical delivery — architecture, backend engineering and security design across client platforms.

- **Four-plane deployment topology** with one-way initiation between planes: a public edge behind CDN and WAF; an SPA plane running a backend-for-frontend that holds the session rather than the tokens; an application plane owning the signing key; and a response-only identity plane on Keycloak issuing OIDC / JWT. Each plane deploys independently with its own secrets, identity and network boundary.
- **Inter-plane trust model:** specified mutual TLS with SPIFFE/SPIRE workload identities at the service-mesh boundary, sequenced as a phase-two deliverable rather than forcing a Kubernetes-shaped stack onto the first release — with Keycloak service accounts as the documented interim, and the gap recorded as a critical open item rather than left implicit. (*Vite / React SPA, .NET services, PostgreSQL, Redis, RabbitMQ, outbox and dispatcher pattern, gRPC over HTTP/2 for service-to-service.*)
- **Isolation strategy for the ledger boundary:** moving the plane that carries the banking core off shared-kernel containers onto **KVM-backed microVM isolation** (RustVMM-based sandboxing — hardware-level separation at tens-of-milliseconds startup), so a container escape in an adjacent workload cannot reach the ledger. Currently under evaluation rather than in production.
- **Containerised platform across four environments** (development, staging, production and a legacy-migration path) — nginx edge, Django / Django REST Framework on PostgreSQL, Redis, Azure Functions, Azure Blob Storage and Communication Services, with Prometheus, Grafana and the Elastic Stack for observability, behind an isolated container network.
- Architecture decisions recorded as **ADRs with formal supersession**, so topology changes carry their own rationale rather than being reconstructed from commit history.

Solutions Architect / Technical Lead — Core Financial Systems

Raging River Trading (Pty) Ltd · Fintech / Gaming · Dec 2022 – Mar 2026

Led the architectural transformation of core financial systems, replacing a legacy banking platform with a modern, white-label engine handling high-volume transactions across Africa’s largest gaming brands. Architecturally responsible for the processing flow, multi-tenancy strategy, and concurrency design, working in close partnership with the Enterprise Architect.

- **Multi-tenancy & data segregation:** Designed a three-level hierarchy — tenant, brand, payment method — in which **configuration inherits top-down and is overridable at any level, while financial data inherits nothing and is hard-segregated per brand**, each brand sitting independently in SOX scope. Brand does not reliably map to country (a cryptocurrency brand maps to none), so resolution ran per brand-and-payment-method with tenant defaults beneath rather than a country lookup. In production: 2 tenants, 25 brands, 150+ payment methods.
- **Schema-per-brand under a hard constraint:** Separate databases per brand were priced out and the data already sat in SQL Server, so 25 brands shared one database by schema separation — one EF Core code-first model defined once and deployed 25 times, giving every brand an identical shape and a single migration path instead of 25 divergent ones. Per-brand context instances with capped pools, bound to the request by an edge auth filter resolving API key to brand; contexts scoped per request and never shared, so isolation followed the request scope.
- **Ledger access boundary:** An orchestration API in front of a locked-down data-access API — only orchestration could mutate the ledger — with brand resolved from an API key at an edge filter, so no caller could reach another brand’s data by construction.
- **Concurrency & ledger integrity:** Designed idempotent withdrawal processing under contention: each request creates an attempt record keyed to a unique identifier; on confirmation that identifier drives the ledger deduction, guarded by a rowversion (SQL timestamp) optimistic- concurrency check so updates only succeed if the row is unchanged since read — exactly-once behaviour for the debit. Supported both back-office-reviewed and automated “auto-cash-in” approval flows.
- **Request path (withdrawal):** REST initiation → input validation → configured strategy rules (FICA / playthrough / AML as required by brand and method, executed via an integration adapter) → attempt record keyed by a unique trace id (the idempotency key) → confirmation drives the ledger debit under **rowversion** → state change and outbox message commit in the same **SaveChangesAsync** → consumers drain; poison goes to a DLQ. A retry of the same trace id is the same attempt.
- **Work discovery & delivery:** Replaced chronological state-polling — contention by design, and liable to miss a row that commits after the scan has passed its timestamp — with a **transactional outbox committed inside SaveChangesAsync**, so a state change and the message announcing it land together and nothing scans business tables to find work. Drained to per-brand queues with dead-lettering, so segregation held to the messaging layer and no brand backlog could stall another.
- **Performance & storage strategy:** Applied in-memory (memory-optimised) tables with non-sequential keys on high-contention paths. Tuned fill factors separately to reduce last-page insert contention on hot indexes. Implemented tiered partitioning with progressive cold-archiving (detaching yearly partitions into separate databases on colder servers) to meet multi-year regulatory retention while keeping hot ledger tables performant.
- **Resilience:** Used exponential backoff with retries, circuit breakers, and dead-letter queues to prevent thundering-herd failures, on high-availability clusters with redundant storage.
- **Integration platform:** Worked on the platform where integrations are managed, routed and reconciled — abstracting 150+ money processors across online (callback/polling) and offline (e.g. USSD-reconciled) flows — and built integrations on it. Provider payloads were reshaped to the core contract by per-provider **IronPython** marshalling hosted in the .NET backend. **Rewrote the engine that moves each integration into its own instance**, so a single slow or chatty provider could no longer exhaust a shared thread pool or exhaust host sockets.
- **Large-scale migration:** Moved roughly **150 million records** across a high-throughput Saturday — peak trading rather than a quiet maintenance window — with **no drop in the New Relic Apdex score**.
- **Delivery & operations:** Practised trunk-based development with feature flags; defined build pipelines and shipped to production several times daily via automated CI/CD, with canary releases, health checks, and early-warning telemetry.

- **Stakeholders:** Acted as the bridge between engineering and the business (product owners, business analysts, marketing, client retention), translating feature needs into a sustainable architecture without sacrificing long-term integrity for short-term wins.

Segregation was enforced in application code — an auth filter and a resolver deciding which schema a request reached. It satisfies an auditor, but a single bug in that path has nothing beneath it; the barrier belongs in the engine, which on PostgreSQL is `SET LOCAL search_path` scoped to the transaction plus row-level security, where a missed predicate returns zero rows.

Role concluded via voluntary severance during a post-acquisition restructure.

Software Developer

MeterMo · Utilities / Automated Metering · Apr 2022 – Dec 2022

Platform modernisation and maintenance across an automated utility-metering estate — electricity, water and gas usage capture and reporting. Migrated six projects from Team Foundation Server to Azure DevOps and brought them up to current frameworks and package versions; maintained two APIs, two cross-platform field apps and two websites. Platform debt is a tax on every feature that comes after it; this cleared it.

Software Developer (Specialist Problem-Solver)

Dotcom Software Solutions · Fintech consulting · Jan 2022 – Apr 2022

Specialist problem-solver for complex challenges other team members could not resolve, within the fintech consulting space for clients including Nedbank, Standard Bank, and PSG Wealth.

- **Legacy upgrade (Standard Bank – Schemes Bot):** Upgraded the Schemes (Stokvel / Chama) BotFramework backend from .NET Standard to .NET 6, resolving critical breaking changes and package dependencies — previously attempted and rolled back by others. Live and stable in production since February 2022. Also handled monetization design and payment validations. (*Azure SQL, BotFramework, C# .NET 6 (from .NET Standard), MediatR, Q&A Maker (historical / retired Microsoft service).*)
- **Angular Universal SSR (PSG Wealth):** Implemented server-side rendering to resolve a 2-year SEO bottleneck in one week. (*C# .NET 6, Angular, Azure SQL, BotFramework, Docker, Node.js, Umbraco CMS, MediatR, Bootstrap / Material.*)

Senior Developer / Business Analyst / Team Lead

Payteq (Pty) Ltd · Fintech · Apr 2020 – Jan 2022

- **GoTrips (Team Lead | Full Rewrite):** Led the ground-up rewrite of a struggling platform, eliminating years of technical debt and introducing proper coding standards, design principles, and performance optimisations. (*C# .NET Core API, PostgreSQL, Angular, Azure CI/CD, FluentValidation, Azure Functions.*)
- **Veriseal (Solo Migration):** Single-handedly migrated a critical compliance platform (KYC, AML, mass payments, bank-account verification) from legacy ASP.NET to .NET Core API with Angular 8, with meticulous attention to data integrity and security. (*.NET Core, SQL, SSRS, FluentValidation, AutoMapper.*)
- **GoBills (Team Lead):** Led development of a scalable business-management solution (inventory, POS, financials) with a sophisticated RBAC system governing permissions and client access. (*.NET Core API, Angular 8, Identity Framework, Dependency Injection, custom CMS, Bootstrap / Angular Material.*)
- **Interchange IDE & Insight Server:** Go-to consultant for a highly scalable messaging-middleware integration platform with RBAC, providing ongoing support and maintenance on a SaaS basis.

Software Developer / Business Analyst

iPlan Global · Supply Chain / Manufacturing / Mining / Industrial / Automation · Oct 2017 – Apr 2020

Delivered tailored solutions across Supply Chain, Manufacturing, Mining, and Industrial sectors as both developer and analyst, including solution-architecture design.

- **Consolidated Job Dashboard:** Automated a previously manual, error-prone supply-chain consolidation process. (*VBScript, SQL.*)
- **Espresso Quote Application:** Solo full-stack mobile quoting app with integrated email delivery and manager-approval workflows. (*C# .NET, Entity Framework, MVC, jQuery, AJAX, JavaScript, SQL.*)
- **ASP.NET Food Portal:** Distributed compliance/tracking system for farmers to log deliveries and track poison-testing results, enforcing user security across multiple locations. (*ASP.NET, C# .NET, XAML/MVVM.*)
- **Espresso RepCheckIn:** Rep-tracking and route-optimisation system with tiered priority visit lists. (*JavaScript, C# .NET, jQuery, MVC, AJAX.*)

Software Developer (C# .NET)

Novigo (Pty) Ltd · Recruitment · Apr 2017 – Oct 2017

Sole developer and IT administrator for a recruitment firm: designed, built, and deployed a complete ERP from the ground up, including Linux server setup, domain hosting, and general IT support. (*C# .NET WinForms, MySQL, Linux.*)

AI & Multi-Model Engineering

Multi-model evaluation practice. Runs five commercial assistants concurrently — Claude (primary), GitHub Copilot, Cursor, OpenAI Codex and Grok — as a deliberate comparison harness rather than a single-vendor commitment, with a considered position on where each is strongest and where consistency breaks down. Workflows are kept OpenAI API-compatible so any conformant provider is a drop-in.

Agent orchestration framework. Designed and built an end-to-end pipeline that decomposes a brief into a dependency-aware DAG of work items — each tagged with complexity, a preferred model tier and a token/tool-call budget — then executes them in parallel across specialist sub-agents under an overseer that resolves blockers, re-plans failed items and downgrades models on weighted cost/performance criteria. Architecture decisions are captured as ADRs *while the plan is formed*, not retrofitted afterwards.

Cost governance. Sub-agent execution is gated by user-defined session budgets with pre-flight estimates of token and tool-call spend and a live plan-versus-actual dashboard — the control layer that makes multi-agent work economically predictable rather than open-ended.

Automated quality gate (“strict mode”). A review workflow that grades output — from orchestration runs, peers or personal work — against versioned design-guideline references, then enforces it: all analyzers enabled, warnings as errors, a tiered diagnostic list and a self-extending recipe book of resolution strategies. Mechanical fixes route to cheaper models; only unknown diagnostics and public-API-affecting changes escalate to a senior model. Includes custom Roslyn analyzers and a templated `.editorconfig` injected per project.

Two-axis automated code review. Separates “*does this follow our documented standards and ADRs?*” from “*does this do what the work item actually asked for?*”, running both as parallel sub-agents and reporting them side by side rather than collapsing them into a single verdict.

Reusable engineering tooling. Maintains a versioned library of skills, agents, commands and hooks with a two-layer publish/capture model, distributed across machines and packaged as a portable plugin. Conventions are published openly as [engineering-standards](#) — vendored into downstream repositories

and kept current by an automated sync PR. Model context is extended through MCP server integration across cloud, design and developer tooling.

Frontier tooling evaluation. Runs a standing evaluation of emerging agent infrastructure beyond the mainstream assistants — agent frameworks (Hermes / Nous Research), model-routing layers (Omniroute, 9Router) and persistent memory and context systems (Perseus, Mnemonic AI) — to track where the practical ceiling on context persistence, routing economics and agent autonomy is moving, ahead of it becoming standard practice.

Notable Clients Engaged (Across Consulting Roles)

Bankserv (now PayInc), Standard Bank, Nedbank, PSG Wealth, Libstar Holdings, Translution.

Open source

- **CombinatorialOptimiser** — <https://github.com/RichardvZyl/CombinatorialOptimiser> — permutation (TSP), subset selection (knapsack) and constraint assignment (graph colouring). Exact (Held-Karp, DP, branch-and-bound), construction, improvement (2-opt, Lin-Kernighan) and metaheuristics (simulated annealing, genetic algorithm, ILS). A solver registry recommends by instance size so $O(n!)$ is never the plan. Packable as NuGet; not published to nuget.org.
 - **engineering-standards** — repository conventions used across delivery work.
 - **pseudo-random-guaranteed-unique** — T-SQL uniqueness without a random collision window.
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Certifications, Education & Profile

- **IKM C# Assessment:** 73rd percentile of all test takers (assessed twice, six months apart).
- **National Diploma — IT: Software Development:** Varsity College, 2014–2016.